

I bumped it up to 40 threads, the phone throttled to 35 per cent of its peak performance. This is worse sustained performance than the Pixel 7s.

All in all, a phone that costs over a lakh is getting outperformed by last year's Snapdragon 8+ Gen 1 which powers phones at the ₹30-40K price point. While benchmarks aren't the full story, this is not a great look for the Pixel. In real-world performance, the phone is smooth enough for normal tasks, but if you record at 4K for more than 5 minutes or play a round or two of BGMI, the phone heats up considerably. I also experienced some jitters and lag and apps also take longer than usual to open. Not a flagship experience in any way.

UI & AI

Google's commitment to software updates on the eve of the launch of the new Pixel devices shocked the tech world – in a good way. The company has promised that the Pixel 8 family will receive 7 years of major OS updates and security updates, which is higher than what Apple promises! Google also assured that spare parts for the devices will be available for 7 years as well, which is fantastic for the end user.

The phone comes with stock Android 14 out of the box, and the bloatware-free experience is always refreshing after using phones from companies such as Xiaomi, Samsung, OPPO, and more. Like the Pixel 7 series, the Pixel 8 Pro also came with some software niggles at launch. There were a couple of annoying bugs such as the AOD screen flickering, Bluetooth connectivity issues, and more present at the time.

However, I've been using the Pixel 8 Pro for 3 whole weeks now and the newest update did alleviate some of these issues. One bug/issue that persisted is unreliable Wi-Fi connectivity. I didn't face too many network or mobile data issues, but the Wi-Fi connection seems to be a bit wonky. It consistently delivers slower Wi-Fi speeds than other phones connected to the same Wi-Fi network. Another issue that hasn't been fixed is that software updates take forever to download, which can get really annoying. All in all, the UI is

extremely clean and reasonably smooth, however, issues like these can mar the overall experience.

As for the Pixel 8 Pro's AI abilities, some of these are truly akin to magic. The end result, that is. The waiting and pondering about your life while the AI does its thing; not so much. Some of the best AI features on the Pixel 8 Pro are the brand-new Magic Editor, Audio Magic Eraser and Best Take. Magic Editor lets you isolate a subject in a picture and place them anywhere you like. Similar to Midjourney, the phone spits out four samples for you to choose your favourite from.

In my time testing Magic Editor, it has thrown up some insanely impressive results but the processing takes FOREVER since the processing is not all happening on the device. In fact, to edit any photo via Magic Editor, it must first be backed up to Google Photos, which is an annoyance in itself. Best Take uses Google's AI to allow you to choose the best face/pose out of a bunch of similar pictures taken in succession – again, it works wonders but the final result takes far too long to process.

Audio Magic Eraser can eliminate ambient sound from recorded videos – a powerful tool for creators who use their phones to shoot content. Now, all these features are path-breaking but the end user experience is slightly lacklustre given how much waiting time there is. The whole process just feels far from being smooth. Magical, sure, but not smooth.

I hope this can be ironed out in the future since the features can actually end up being super useful. In my opinion, people will be deterred from actually using these features on a day-to-day basis if they take too long to process. In addition to these features, you've also got a few others such as call screening (still not supported in India), Live Translate, and Live Transcribe. You also get support for lossless audio using wired headphones.

BATTERY LIFE

In our 4K video loop test, the Pixel 8 Pro survived nearly 15 hours at full brightness while playing a 4K video on VLC on loop. The Pixel 8 Pro consistently gave me

screen-on times of 7+ hours with the latest update. The standby time was also pretty decent, however, my colleague Darab had a bad experience with standby time on the vanilla Pixel 8. Pixel's AI also learns your usage patterns and improves battery consumption over time. The charging speeds, sadly, are on the slower side. My Pixel 8 Pro review unit took over 1 and a half hours to charge to full. The phone only comes equipped with 30 W wired charging which is decimated by the likes of Xiaomi, OnePlus, and OPPO fast chargers.

There is support for 23 W wireless charging (using Pixel's wireless charging stand) and reverse wireless charging, which is pretty neat. If you're using a normal Qi wireless charger, wireless charging speeds are capped at 12 W.

VERDICT

At ₹1,06,999, the Pixel 8 Pro is honestly very hard to recommend amidst the landscape of stellar flagship smartphones in India. The improvements don't measure up to the ginormous ₹22,000 price hike from the Pixel 7 Pro. Pixel fans will certainly eat up the improvements to AI features and camera, but for the general user, there's not enough polish to convince them to grab a Pixel 8 Pro over the iPhone 15 series or the Samsung Galaxy S23 Ultra. The phone will have to be much cheaper for me to comfortably recommend it. Say about ₹22,000 cheaper?

–Dhriti Datta

SPECIFICATIONS

Processor: Google Tensor G3, Titan M2 security coprocessor | RAM: 12 GB LPDDR5X | ROM: 128 GB UFS 3.1 | Display: 6.7-inch LTPO AMOLED, HDR10+, 24-bit depth for 16 million colours | Display resolution: 1344 x 2992 pixels, 489 PPI | Display refresh rate: 1-120 Hz | Protection: Corning Gorilla Glass Victus 2 | IP Rating: IP68 | Brightness: Up to 1,600 nits (HDR) and up to 2,400 nits (peak brightness) | Thickness: 8.8 mm | Weight: 213 g | Cameras (rear): 50 MP Laser AF & OIS, 48 MP telephoto OIS & 5x optical zoom, 48 MP ultra-wide | Camera (front): 10.5 MP | Battery capacity: 5,050 mAh | Charging: 30 W wired, 23 W wireless, Reverse wireless | Colours: Obsidian, Bay

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